Lecture 1: Introduction

Introduction to Psychology · Yale University, Spring 2007 · Professor Paul Bloom

Study guide based on the lecture transcript. Source: https://oyc.yale.edu/psychology/psyc-110/lecture-1 (CC BY-NC-SA 3.0).

Before you start

In this first lecture, Professor Paul Bloom explains how the course works and what psychology studies. He names the five main sub-areas of psychology. Then he gives five examples of course topics: the brain, children, attractiveness, good and evil, and mental illness. The lecture is a map of the whole course.

Learning goals

After this lecture you should be able to:

- Name and describe the five sub-areas of psychology.
- Explain why the course also uses ideas from other fields, such as economics, philosophy and computer science.
- Describe the main questions of developmental psychology: what is built in, what comes from culture, and why people are different.
- Give an example of a rare mental disorder and explain why studying extreme cases helps us understand normal life.

Key ideas

1. Introduction to and Requirements for the Course

- The course is "a comprehensive introduction to the study of the human mind." Topics include brains, children, language, sex, memory, madness, disgust, racism and love.
- There are two lectures a week and course readings. Students must do both. Some readings do not appear in the lectures, and some lectures do not connect to the readings.
- There are two books: Peter Gray's *Psychology* (5th edition) and *The Norton Reader*, a collection of short readings edited by Gary Marcus.
- Evaluation: a Midterm and a Final (multiple choice and short answer), short weekly questions marked pass/fail, a short book review, and an experimental participation requirement (taking part in psychology studies).
- Professor Bloom's advice for doing well: attend all the classes, keep up with the readings (ideally before class), and form study groups.

2. General Goals for the Course

- Scientific psychology has real-world uses, for example for how you study, how you persuade people and what therapy works best.

- But the main goal is bigger: "a state of the art introduction to the most important topic that there is: us." The course asks how the human mind works and what makes us what we are.
- Psychology is often divided into five sub-areas:
  - **Neuroscience:** studying the mind by looking at the brain.
  - **Developmental:** how people develop, grow and learn. This is Professor Bloom's own main area.
  - **Cognitive:** a computational approach. It often compares the mind to a computer and studies how people understand language, recognize objects and play games.
  - **Social:** how people act in groups and with other people.
  - **Clinical:** the study of mental health and mental illness.
- Professor Bloom believes you cannot study the mind with psychology alone. The course also connects to evolution, economics and game theory, philosophy, computer science, anthropology, literature and theology.

3. Examples of Materials Covered in the Course

- **The brain.** Terri Schiavo was in a coma, without consciousness, because of damage to her brain. Her case is "a stark illustration of the physical nature of mental life." The course begins with the question of how a physical thing can give rise to mental life.
- **Children.** Developmental psychologists ask how much of our knowledge is innate (built in) and how much comes from culture, language and schooling. They ask about continuity: can you see the adult in the child? (The poet William Wordsworth wrote, "The child is father to the man.") And they ask why people are different: is it genes, environment, or an interaction? The poet Philip Larkin wrote that parents "mess you up." How much parents matter is very controversial.
- **Attractiveness.** Scientists show people computer-generated faces and ask for ratings. In this way they learn what makes a face attractive, within cultures and across cultures.
- **Good and evil.** Examples of evil in the slides included Osama bin Laden and Ted Bundy. Examples of good were Oskar Schindler (in the Holocaust) and Paul Rusesabagina (in Rwanda), who saved many lives at great risk to themselves. A key question: is being good or bad part of your nature, or is it mostly the result of the situation?
- **Mental illness.** The course will cover common disorders, like depression and anxiety, and also rare ones:
  - Phineas Gage was a construction worker. In an explosion, a metal pipe went through his head. He survived, but he lost his sense of right and wrong and his self-control.
  - In **Capgras syndrome** (often caused by a stroke), a person believes that the people they love most have been replaced, for example by robots or aliens.
  - In **Cotard's syndrome**, a person believes that they are dead.
- Why study rare cases? "By looking at extreme cases, they can help us best understand normal life." For example, Capgras syndrome shows that recognizing something (being able to name it) is different from knowing what it is.

- Four guest lecturers will speak: Dr. Marvin Chun (cognitive neuroscience of faces), Dr. Susan Nolen-Hoeksema (depression), Kelly Brownell (the psychology of food) and Dr. Peter Salovey (love).

Key vocabulary

Term	Meaning in simple English	Example from the lecture
neuroscience	Studying the mind by looking at the brain	Terri Schiavo's brain damage and her loss of consciousness
developmental psychology	Studying how people develop, grow and learn	How children come to understand language, objects and people
cognitive psychology	Studying the mind as a kind of computer	How people understand language and recognize objects
social psychology	Studying how people act in groups and with others	Why people "go crazy in groups"
clinical psychology	Studying mental health and mental illness	Depression and anxiety disorders
innate	Present from birth; built in ("hard-wired")	How much of our knowledge is innate, and how much comes from schooling?
continuity	Staying the same over time	"The child is father to the man"
genes and environment	What we inherit, compared with how we are raised and what we experience	Why people differ in IQ, taste in food or politics
coma	A state without consciousness	Terri Schiavo, after damage to her brain
delusion	A strong belief that is false	Believing your father has been replaced by a robot
Capgras syndrome	A disorder in which you believe your loved ones have been replaced	Loved ones replaced by "aliens or robots"
Cotard's syndrome	A disorder in which you believe you are dead	You walk around, but you think you are dead
controversial	Causing a lot of disagreement	How much parents shape their children

Check your understanding

1. What are the five sub-areas of psychology that Professor Bloom names?
2. Why does Professor Bloom say students must attend the lectures and also do the readings?
3. What does cognitive psychology often compare the mind to? Give one thing it studies.
4. In developmental psychology, what does it mean to ask how much of our knowledge is innate?
5. What does Wordsworth's line "The child is father to the man" mean?
6. What happened to Phineas Gage after his accident, and what does his case show?

7. Compare Capgras syndrome and Cotard's syndrome.
8. Professor Bloom says we do not study rare disorders because they are frequent or because of "morbid curiosity." Why do we study them? Give one example.

Answer guide

1. Neuroscience, developmental, cognitive, social and clinical psychology.
2. The lectures and readings only partly overlap. Some readings are not in the lectures, and some lectures do not connect to the readings.
3. To a computer. It studies things like how people understand language, recognize objects and play games.
4. It asks how much of our knowledge is built in from birth, and how much comes from culture, language and schooling.
5. You can see in every child the adult he or she will become. The course asks if this is true for personality, interests and intelligence.
6. He lost his sense of right and wrong and his self-control; he could not keep a job and got into fights. It shows how the brain gives rise to the mind, and how brain damage can change a person.
7. In both, a person holds a strange false belief, and both involve the same parts of the brain. In Capgras, you believe your loved ones have been replaced. In Cotard's, you believe you are dead.
8. Extreme cases help us understand normal life. For example, Capgras syndrome shows that recognizing something (being able to name it) is different from knowing what it is.

English practice

Useful phrases from the lecture

- "What I want to do is..." - introduces the speaker's plan or goal. Example: "What I want to do is provide a state of the art introduction..."
- "To what extent...?" - asks how much something is true. Example: "To what extent is your fate sealed?"
- "...is a stark illustration of..." - a very clear example of something. Example: a case like this "is a stark illustration of the physical nature of mental life."
- "It's very controversial." - people strongly disagree about it. Use it for open questions in science.
- "...things we naturally take for granted" - things we accept without thinking about them.

Speaking task (with your AI tutor)

- Explain the five sub-areas of psychology in 4-6 sentences. Use these terms: *neuroscience*, *cognitive*, *clinical*.
- Explain why rare disorders help us understand normal life in 4-6 sentences. Use these terms: *delusion*, *Capgras syndrome*, *extreme cases*.

Writing task

- Write one paragraph (80-120 words): Explain the "genes and environment" question from the lecture. Give one example of a way people differ, and describe the three possible kinds of answer that Professor Bloom mentions (genes, how we were raised, or an interaction).

Study with your tutor

Things to say to your tutor in Live conversation:

- "Let's review Lecture 1. Ask me questions about the five sub-areas of psychology, one at a time."
- "Quiz me on the key vocabulary of Lecture 1."
- "I will explain why studying rare disorders like Capgras syndrome helps us understand normal life. Check my understanding and my English."
- "Give me an example of a difference between people, and ask me to explain it in terms of genes and environment."

Readings from the original course

- Gray, Peter. Psychology (5th edition), chapter 1
- Stanovich, Keith. "How to Think Straight about Psychology." In The Norton Psychology Reader. Edited by Gary Marcus. New York: W. W. Norton & Company, 2006. pp. 27-37

My notes